

Getting Lost in the Woods: Lessons from Transcendentalism



What would happen if you abandoned everything right now and isolated yourself in the woods for two years? Probably nothing good. You'd be bitten by ticks and mosquitoes. You'd pass out from heat stroke and dehydration. You'd be scared of crazy people stumbling upon your abode. In 2026, abandoning life is unrealistic. However, in 1845, [Henry David Thoreau](#) did just that: built himself a small shack on Walden Pond in Concord, Massachusetts. He spent two years growing food, meditating, observing nature, and most famously, gathering fodder for his book, *Walden*.

Thoreau was a key figure in [Transcendentalism](#), a philosophy originating in Cambridge, Massachusetts. Among individuality, intuition, and divinity, transcendentalists believed in the sacred, innate connection of humans with nature. Notions of American exceptionalism and westward expansion were simultaneously circulating throughout the country during the rise of transcendentalism. Americans were looking for opportunity, and saw that opportunity in land, gold, and farming of the West. Depicted in *American Progress* by John Gast, the flowy white robes of an angel pan across the painting, moving light from East to West, illustrating the belief

that American settlers were both inevitable and imperative for the prosperity of the nation [PHOTO: [LINK](#)]. However, the transcendentalists fundamentally disagreed with the idea of [Manifest Destiny](#) and the belief that nature is something to be conquered, exploited, and owned.

Thoreau's friend and mentor, [Ralph Waldo Emerson](#) is considered the pioneer of transcendentalism. In Cambridge, he first founded the [Transcendental Club](#), where like-minded intellectuals and scholars gathered, notably including Margaret Fuller and George Putnam. Following the meeting, he released his first essay, *Nature*, which possessed an unprecedented reverence for the natural environment. Emerson wrote, "When I behold a rich landscape, I feel a tranquil sense of [unity](#)." This feeling of peace and connection with nature is a foundational belief in transcendentalism. More spiritually, a sense of divinity and [enlightenment](#) was present in the writing.

Taking after his mentor, Thoreau became a key figure in transcendentalism and philosophical history. Building upon notions of the connection between humans and nature, he decided to conduct an "experiment" by living in the woods for two years. Along the shores of Walden Pond, he discovered what it truly meant to immerse himself in the environment. This experiment was also a rejection of society's extractive and materialistic values, occurring on the heels of the First Industrial Revolution in New England [PHOTO: [LINK](#)]. He further rejected the [anthropocentric view](#), where humans are seen as superior to nature and other animals. Instead of taking advantage of the environment for his own benefit, he committed himself to live in harmony with his surroundings. Thoreau's most famous quote from *Walden*, "I went to the woods because I wished to live deliberately...", encompasses the quintessential spirit of transcendentalism. Thoreau desired complete affinity with nature, choosing his own path and living in harmony with his surroundings intentionally.

Yet, are we living deliberately like Thoreau did? How do the views of the past apply today? The transcendentalists directly influenced the conservation movement, leading to the creation of National Parks. Rachel Carson possessed the same wonder and awe for nature that Thoreau did, leading her to advocate against DDT and pesticides, acting as a catalyst for the US environmental movement and the creation of the Environmental Protection Agency. Now, the widespread, modern environmental movement is in response to anthropogenic climate change, with clear philosophical ties to the transcendentalists. Still, it seems we have forgotten our beginnings. Those first meetings in a tiny house in Cambridge, Massachusetts have become lost on us. What happened to the wondrous, harmonious relationship between nature and humans?

In a world so incongruous to that of the transcendentalists', there is one thing that remains: nature. Horseshoe crabs still migrate across Maryland's beaches. The Appalachian Mountains still soar high in the east. The hot springs of Yellowstone still erupt. However, the attitude of exploitation and personal gain from Manifest Destiny exists on a more drastic level. Corporate and fossil fuel executives view nature as a resource meant to be taken. Our feelings towards the natural world have become filled with ignorance and negligence. Instead of living in mutualism with nature, where both parties benefit and live in harmony, we have fostered a world of parasitism, where we take, and take, and take, until eventually, there is nothing left.

We have forgotten what it means to live intentionally with respect to the natural world. Intentionally means admiring the oceans, mountains, and hills rolling before us. Intentionally means considering how the climate crisis disproportionately affects people in the United States. Intentionally means actively making a concerted effort to live more sustainably. Striving for intention over ignorance. Care over complacency. Empathy over ego [PHOTO: [LINK](#)].

As leaders in government and corporations brazenly lack intention, care, and empathy, we must choose to live deliberately. A wave of American exceptionalism is upon us. Despite having no room for westward expansion, we are still looking for ways to take over the landscape. We are squeezing the earth dry through the extraction and burning of fossil fuels, deforestation, and overfishing, while attitudes of materialism, overconsumption, and alienation are imbued in our mindsets.

So no, living in the woods for two years is not the solution to climate change. However, harmony with nature, rejection of exploitation and materialism, and inherent connection with one's surroundings are all lessons that must stay with us when making decisions that impact our world. Most of us are scared of getting lost in the woods. But, maybe, we shouldn't be. Instead, we should be scared of losing the woods entirely, of forgetting our beginnings and beliefs. Although living deliberately may have been a choice in Thoreau's time, for us, it might be the only way to ensure our woods stay rooted to the ground.